What Epic is

Epic is a computer system hospitals use to keep patients' medical records. Instead of paper files, everything about a patient (past illnesses, medicines, test results, appointments, bills) is stored on the computer. Epic is the most popular one in US hospitals, used by roughly 4 in 10 of them.

Why hospitals buy it

- **Everything in one place.** Without it, a hospital might use many different systems that don't talk to each other. Epic puts it all together.
- **Everyone sees the same information.** Doctors, nurses, the lab and the pharmacy all work from the same record.
- **It's the safe, popular choice.** Many big hospitals already use it, so it feels low-risk.
- **Hospitals can share records.** If a patient goes to another hospital that uses Epic, their information can follow them.

The downside is that it's expensive and hard to set up.

How it helps doctors

- They can see a patient's full history quickly instead of searching for papers.
- It warns them about problems, like a medicine that clashes with another one.
- When a doctor orders a test or a medicine, it goes straight to the lab or pharmacy.
- The whole care team stays on the same page, so fewer things get missed or repeated.

One common complaint is that doctors spend a lot of time typing notes into it, so newer tools that write the notes for them are being added.

Wednesday: Find out what main medical areas Lurie is famous for?

Lurie Childrens hospital is for children only, in Chicago. It's #1 in Illinois and ranked in all 11 children's specialties by U.S. News.

Its strongest areas (U.S. News 2025-26):

- Kidney and bladder care: #6
- Kidney health: #7
- Brain, nerves and spine: #7
- Stomach and digestion: #11
- Hormones and diabetes: #11

Other ranked areas: Heart care (#17), lung care (#17), cancer (#19), bones and muscles (#20), newborn care (#23), and behavioral health (ranked, no number).

Biggest standout: Newsweek ranked it #1 in the U.S. for heart care and lung care in 2026. Heart care has held that spot three years in a row.

THURSDAY

Epic dislikes -

- Too many clicks (more time on the screen than with patients)

- Confusing screens (hard to find things, program could lag and slow down, remembering button names)

- Stacks and stacks of paperwork to fill (leads to burnout)

- Millions of dollars required for the setup (A group of hospitals in boston spend 1.2 billion dollars on setting epic up)

- Hard to setup (A hospital saw fewer patients so the staff could learn the system)

FRIDAY

Sharing records: Lurie lets other children's doctors use its computer record system. That way, a child's health history is all in one place, and every doctor can see it.

Research: Lurie's research team works closely with Northwestern University. They are just one block apart. Sometimes they study a problem together with other hospitals and share what they learn.

Keeping information private: Lurie follows a law that protects health information. Mistakes have still happened. In 2019, a worker looked at records they had no reason to see. In 2024, Lurie shut down its computers after seeing suspicious activity.

What I wasnt able to find: How Lurie decides who can use patient information for research. Epic can connect with other companies' tools in two ways.

1. Other companies' apps can plug into Epic

- Epic gives app makers a standard way to connect, so an app can open right inside Epic's screens.
- App makers have to join Epic's program, called Showroom, and pay a yearly fee of about $500. Another membership costs about $1,900 a year.
- Each hospital must approve an app before using it, and many only allow apps listed in Showroom. So an app maker can't connect once and work everywhere. One expert said the job is "20% development, 80% negotiation."

2. Epic can share patient records with other hospitals

- Epic has a tool called Care Everywhere. A doctor can use it to ask another hospital for a patient's records.
- Epic says about half of these requests go to hospitals that don't use Epic. That number comes from Epic itself.
- Epic also joined a national sharing network called TEFCA. More than 1,000 hospitals are connected to it through Epic.
- It doesn't always work. When the records start outside Epic, there can still be gaps.

The big idea: Epic does let others connect, but Epic decides how.